Ambiguous perspective in narrative discourse: Effects of viewpoint markers and verb tense on readers' interpretation of represented perceptions

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Ambiguous Perspective in Narrative Discourse: Effects of Viewpoint Markers and Verb Tense on Readers' Interpretation of Represented Perceptions

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ABSTRACT

Narratives frequently represent perceptions that allow for multiple interpretations in terms of perspective: Perceptions can be interpreted from the narrator's viewpoint as well as the character's viewpoint. Two experiments examined the role of contextual viewpoint markers and verb tense in readers' interpretation of such ambiguous perceptions. Whereas verb tense did not affect perceptual attributions in Experiment 1, viewpoint markers did: Readers tended to ascribe an ambiguous perception more strongly to the character in stories with (vs. without) a viewpoint marker in the context. This finding was replicated and extended in Experiment 2, which examined the scope of perceptual attributions by measuring readers' interpretation of three subsequent ambiguous perceptions. Again, verb tense had no effect on perceptual attributions, whereas viewpoint markers did: Readers ascribed each of the three perceptions more strongly to the character in stories with (vs. without) a contextual viewpoint marker. These results advance our understanding of narrative perspective by revealing the influence of local linguistic viewpoint markers on readers' interpretation of stories stretches to the discourse level.

Introduction

Narrative discourse is characterized by the representation of viewpoints. The objects, events, and situations in a story can be narrated from the viewpoint of the narrator, the viewpoint of a character, or the viewpoints of multiple characters. Most often, and in particular in stories written in the third person, story parts narrated from the narrator's viewpoint alternate with story parts narrated from the viewpoint of a character. Processing this complex interplay between viewpoints relies heavily on linguistic markers that signal the introduction of a new viewpoint or the transfer from one viewpoint to another (Dancygier, 2012). These viewpoint markers include various types of discourse representation, such as direct and free indirect speech and thought (see, e.g., Leech & Short, 2007), but also more subtle linguistic elements that give expression to a character's perceptual or mental state, such as verbs of seeing and verbs of cognition (Brinton, 1980).

The absence of viewpoint markers can result in ambiguous represented observations; in such cases it is often impossible to determine with certainty whether a narrated observation is described from the perspective of the narrator or the perspective of the character. An intriguing question is how readers interpret stretches of narrative discourse in which the perspective is ambiguous. However, despite longstanding, and contradictory, theoretical claims about readers' processing of narrated observations that allow for multiple interpretations (Brinton, 1980; Caenepeel, 1989; Farner,

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2014; Palmer, 2004; Sanders, 1994), empirical research testing these claims remains lacking. The goal of the present study is to fill part of this gap by determining how linguistic viewpoint markers and verb tense affect readers' interpretation of ambiguous perspectives.

Linguistic perspective in narratives

Stories can be written in the first person (I-perspective), third person (he/she-perspective), or, although less common, in the second person (you-perspective). Choice of grammatical person affects readers' processing of a story in terms of the position they take relative to the story's events and characters as well as the strength of their absorption into the story world. For example, various studies have demonstrated that second-person stories lead readers to adopt an embodied actor's perspective, in which they simulate the story events from the spatial viewpoint of the character, whereas first- and third-person stories lead readers to adopt an external perspective, in which they observe the character and events from a distance (Brunyé, Ditman, Mahoney, Augustyn, & Taylor, 2009; Ditman, Brunyé, Mahoney, & Taylor, 2010). In addition, first-person stories have been shown to elicit stronger mental images and a stronger sense of being present in the story world compared with third-person stories, whereas third-person stories elicit slightly more physical arousal than first-person stories (Hartung, Burke, Hagoort, & Willems, 2016).

Although first-person stories are by definition represented from an internal viewpoint, third-person stories can be represented from an internal as well as an external viewpoint (van Krieken, Hoeken, & Sanders, 2017). Narratological research on focalization offers a helpful framework to understand how internal viewpoints can be established in any story, regardless of the grammatical person. The notion of focalization was introduced by Genette (1980) and later elaborated by Bal (1985) to analyze and describe who perceives (i.e., who focalizes) the narrative events. The importance of the concept lies in its distinction from the concept of "voice," which refers to the source narrating the story to the audience (Chatman, 1978; Genette, 1980). Focalization, by contrast, does not refer to the act of narration but to the point of view from which the story events are perceptually represented. Three categories of focalization can be distinguished: zero focalization, in which the narrator describes the story events and characters from an external perspective and knows more than the characters know; external focalization, in which the narrator describes the story events and characters from an external perspective but knows less than the characters know; and internal focalization, in which the narrator describes the story events from the internal perspective of one or more characters and knows neither more nor less than the characters know (Genette, 1980). The technique of internal focalization allows narrators to access the inner life of a character and to describe events and situations from the internal viewpoint of that character, also in third-person stories. Thus, although a story is always rendered through the narrator's voice, the subjective experiences of a third-person character can serve as a filter through which the narrator observes and describes the events and situations (Chatman, 1986). Consider, for example, the following excerpt from the story *The Shape of Things*, written by Truman Capote (1944):

(1) He looked out the window where the dusk was thickening on the pane. Gathering swiftly the blue light and the hill humps blending and echoing one another. He blinked back into the diner's brightness. "Must be Virginia," he guessed and shrugged his shoulders.

In this example, internal focalization is established by linguistic elements that give expression to the character's consciousness in terms of his mental (*guessed*) and perceptual (*looked, blinked*) state. The second, elliptic sentence furthermore suggests that the blue light and hill humps are perceived by the he-character who is looking out the window. The representation of such perceptions has been described as "a literary style whereby an author, instead of describing the external world, expresses a character's perceptions of it, directly as they occur in the character's consciousness" (Brinton, 1980, p. 370).

Linguistic elements expressing a character's viewpoint are ubiquitous in narrative discourse and highly diverse in form and function. The recently developed Linguistic Cues Framework distinguishes a wide range of viewpoint markers based on the specific dimension of the character they give expression to (van Krieken et al., 2017). A character's spatiotemporal position constitutes the most basic viewpoint dimension and is linguistically signaled by choices in grammatical role (subject vs. object; see van Krieken, Sanders, & Hoeken, 2015), tense (present vs. past vs. pluperfect), and deictic elements (proximal vs. distal). Linguistic cues of a character's emotional state, including verbs and adjectives of emotion, express the emotional viewpoint of the character; action verbs give expression to the character as an acting and moving character; and the use of evaluations and attributions expresses the moral state of the character. Linguistic expressions that mark a character's psychological state, such as verbs of cognition, signal the character's psychological viewpoint. Finally, linguistic cues that signal a character's sensory perceptions, such as verbs of seeing and verbs of bodily sensation, express the character's perceptual viewpoint.

Sanders and Redeker (1996) developed a cognitive linguistic framework to analyze the use and functions of these various viewpoint phenomena in narrative discourse. The framework builds on Mental Spaces Theory, which holds that textual information is distributed over various mental spaces (Fauconnier, 1985). Mental spaces are conceptual domains that are set up by linguistic elements and linked to one another with the effect "to create a network of spaces through which we move as discourse unfolds" (Sweetser & Fauconnier, 1996, p. 11). Thus, in processing and understanding texts, readers create a mental representation of these spaces. Applying this premise to narrative discourse, internal focalization takes place when a character-bound mental space is opened up and the validity of the information provided is restricted to this character (Sanders & Redeker, 1996). In such cases, Mental Spaces Theory predicts that readers mentally represent the narrative situation from the viewpoint of the character and thus align their own viewpoints with the character's viewpoint. This alignment can affect readers' interpretation of narrative discourse. For example, experimental research has shown that readers use information about the mental state of characters, as provided by the embedding of character-bound mental spaces in the narrative, to make sense of characters' actions (Foy & Gerrig, 2013).

Mental spaces in narrative discourse are often opened up by linguistic viewpoint markers expressing a character's perceptual or psychological state. Prototypical markers in this respect are verbs of sensory perception and verbs of cognition, for example:

(2a) Peter *heard* the sirens getting closer.
(2b) Peter *felt* the breeze come and go across his body.
(2c) Peter *thought* about his mother.
(2d) Peter *memorized* the telephone number.

In both (2a) and (2b) a perceptual verb opens an embedded mental space representing information that is bound to the character. In (2c) and (2d) this embedded space is opened up by a cognitive verb. Sentences (2a) through (2d) are, in different terminology, perspectivized, and, more specifically, internally focalized.

Ambiguous perspective

Frequently, and in particular in the absence of viewpoint markers, a stretch of narrative discourse allows for ambiguity as to its interpretation in terms of perspective. Palmer (2004, pp. 48–49) uses the term *free indirect perception* to describe such instances, which involve "the recovery of those parts of the discourse that initially appear to be pure narratorial report but that, on reflection, can be read as descriptions of events or states in the storyworld as experienced by a particular fictional mind." The following example, taken from Palmer (2004, pp. 48–49), serves to illustrate this phenomenon:

(3a) He sat on the bench. The train pulled away.

Because of the absence of a viewpoint marker in the first sentence, the observation in the second sentence can be interpreted as originating from the narrator's viewpoint or from the character's viewpoint. The ambiguity becomes even more complex considering an interpretative context in which the train does not pull away from the character but away from the reader with the character sitting on a bench inside the train. In instances like these, a verb of perception can serve a disambiguating function:

(3b) He sat on the bench and watched the train pull away.

It has been proposed that perceptual attributions (i.e., the reader's construction of a link between a character and an observed object, such as the train in example (3)) are made either by means of explicit perceptual verbs (*see, watch*, etc.) or by assessing the likelihood that objects are being perceived by a character (Bortolussi & Dixon, 2003). Thus, in (3a) the absence of a perceptual verb should force readers to assess the likelihood that the train is being observed by the he-character, whereas in (3b) the perceptual verb *watched* should guide readers into attributing the observation of the train to the character.

Yet, it has been claimed that even in the absence of viewpoint markers, when readers have to assess the likelihood that a perception originates from the character's viewpoint, they tend to automatically link the perception to the character rather than the narrator. According to Farner (2014), for example, readers interpret a free indirect perception (he uses the term *associative connection*) by default as a perception of the character. He provides the following example:

(4) Peter stood in front of the window. Outside the sun was shining.

He argues that logical conventions make the reader "understand that the sensory verb is implied and that the sunshine reflects Peter's perceptions" (Farner, 2014, p. 237). Moreover, it has been proposed that if it can be inferred that the character is simply *able* to perceive the described situation, such as in (4), it is plausible to attribute the observation to the character rather than the narrator (Bortolussi & Dixon, 2003).

A similar analysis is provided by Brinton (1980), who claims that represented perceptions of a character can be introduced not only by descriptions of that character's perceptions but also by descriptions of that character's actions which do not explicitly signal the character's viewpoint. Likewise, Caenepeel (1989) poses that sentences with stative aspect (i.e., sentences containing verbs depicting a state of being rather than an action) establish focalization in simple independent main clauses, for instance as in the following example (taken from Sanders, 1994, pp. 33–34):

(5a) He stepped outside. It was a lovely day.

Sanders (1994, pp. 33–34) argues that although such constructions do indeed imply a perceiving character, a verb of perception "can enforce the subjective character of the sentence with stative aspect":

(5b) He looked outside. It was a lovely day.

In this account, the perspective in the second sentence of (5b) is less ambiguous compared with (5a) because the verb *looked* in (5b) explicitly signals the introduction of the character's mental space. Although the observation in the second sentence is not explicitly linked to the character, readers might interpret it as such because of the presence of the viewpoint marker in the preceding sentence and the absence of markers signaling a shift from the character's mental space to another mental space.

The ambiguity involved in the examples above raises the question as to how readers actually interpret perceptions that are not explicitly attributed to a character and neither to the narrator and what linguistic elements in the context steer these interpretations. Surprisingly, empirical studies on perceptual attributions are scarce. A notable exception is a study by Sanford, Clegg, and Majid (1998), who showed that readers are more likely to attribute background information in a narrative, such as information about the physical environment, to main characters (i.e., characters referred to with a name) than to secondary characters (i.e., characters referred to with a role description). In another study, narrative perspective was manipulated by varying referential expressions in terms of pronouns (*he, she*) versus nouns (*the man, the woman*; van Krieken & Sanders, 2017). Participants read a story about two characters, one being referred to with pronouns and the other being referred to with nouns. Among other findings, this study showed that readers tend to ascribe ambiguous thoughts to the character referred to with pronouns rather than the character referred to with nouns. This result can be explained by the notion that third-person pronouns in narratives function as viewpoint markers in that the narrative's viewpoint is located with characters referred to with pronouns rather than with characters referred to with nouns (van Krieken et al., 2015). Thus, these studies have shown that choices in referential expressions play a role in readers' attributions of narrative information to characters, indicating that the interpretation and processing of narrative discourse is not only dependent on the text-wide choice between first and third person but also on more local and often subtle linguistic phenomena.

Despite the multitude of claims about the effects of linguistic viewpoint markers such as perceptual verbs on readers' interpretation of ambiguous perspective in narratives, they have yet to be empirically examined. In light of the contradictory views on the perceptual attributions readers make while processing ambiguous observations, the following research question was formulated:

RQ1 *To what extent do viewpoint markers influence readers' perceptual attributions?*

Verb tense

Verb tense might be a second relevant factor in the perceptual attributions readers make, in particular in combination with perceptual viewpoint markers. A general assumption is that stories in the present tense enhance the immediacy and directness of the narrated events by fictively situating them in the present (Fleischman, 1990; Harvey, 2006; e.g., Sanders, 2010). This assumption also holds for switches from past to present tense within a given story. In conversational stories, for example, switches from past to present and vice versa serve to separate the stories into episodes (Wolfson, 1979). Notably, a switch to the present tense often marks a crucial episode, making the events part of this episode "more vivid by bringing past events into the moment of speaking" (Schiffrin, 1981, p. 58). A similar analysis has been provided for Bible stories, in which a switch from the past tense to the present tense marks the importance of the events about to be narrated and draws readers closer to these events (Yamasaki, 2012).

In terms of viewpoint, Dancygier (2012) argues that this so-called historical present reduces the distance between the viewpoint of the character and the viewpoint of the reader. Empirical support for this contention has been found in an experimental study in which readers were shown to adopt the character's perceptual viewpoint more strongly while reading a story in the present (vs. past) tense (Macrae, 2016). As a consequence, readers might attribute ambiguous narrative observations more strongly to the character rather than the narrator in present tense narratives compared to past tense narratives (e.g., in (6a) compared with (5a)).

(5a) He stepped outside. It was a lovely day.
(6a) He steps outside. It is a lovely day.

In support of this line of reasoning, Damsteegt (2005) posits that the present tense may be read by default as a case of internal focalization. The present tense fulfills, in this account, a perspectivizing function in that it forces an interpretation of the narrated events in which the character, not the narrator, is the implied observer. In addition, Damsteegt (2005) argues that the present tense establishes a direct, unmediated link with a character's mind when used in focalized stories. Similarly, it has been proposed that the use of viewpoint markers in present tense stories serves to represent narrative situations through the online, "current" perceptions and thoughts of characters (Dancygier, 2012). The viewpoints of character and reader become, in other words, blended into one shared viewpoint (van Krieken, Sanders, & Hoeken, 2016). This blending effect may apply in particular to third-person stories, in which the present tense has been shown to make readers more aware of the character's thoughts and perceptions than the past tense, whereas the opposite holds for first-person stories (Segal et al., 1997).

In light of the above, the potential effects of viewpoint markers on readers' interpretation of ambiguous perceptions might be particularly pronounced in present (vs. past) tense stories. Thus, compared with (5b) below, the perception in the second sentence of (6b) can be expected to result in a stronger attribution to the character's perspective:

(5b) He looked outside. It was a lovely day.
(6b) He looks outside. It is a lovely day.

The presumed interplay between viewpoint markers and verb tense makes it relevant to study the role of both factors in readers' interpretation of ambiguous perspectives. Therefore, the following research questions were formulated:

RQ2 *To what extent does verb tense influence readers' perceptual attributions?*

RQ3 *To what extent does verb tense moderate the influence of viewpoint markers on readers' perceptual attributions?*

To answer the research questions, two experimental studies were conducted of which the details and results will be discussed below.

Experiment 1

Methods

Materials

The materials for Experiment 1 consisted of 12 short stories of two sentences. The first sentence of each story introduced a character. The second sentence of each story described a situation that could either be observed by the character or by the narrator. The stories were manipulated on the presence (vs. absence) of a linguistic viewpoint marker in the first sentence and on verb tense (past vs. present). The stories with a viewpoint marker included a verb of visual perception in the first sentence, for example, *to see, to watch, to observe*. In the stories without a viewpoint marker, the perceptual verb was replaced with an action verb (e.g., *to walk, to enter*) or a stance verb (e.g, *to stand, to sit*; Huddleston & Pullum, 2002). The manipulations resulted in four versions of each story. Table 1 provides examples of two of the stories in each of the four versions.

Design

A 2 (viewpoint marker: present vs. absent) × 2 (verb tense: past vs. present) within-subjects design was used. Each participant read 3 stories in each of the four conditions, summing up to a total of 12 stories. Using a Latin square design, four versions of the experiment were created such that each story version was read by an equal number of participants. For example, a quarter of the participants read story 1 in

Table 1. Examples of the Story Versions Used in Experiment 1.

Story Version	Example
- viewpoint marker/past tense	*1a. Peter stood in front of the window. Outside the sun was shining.* *2a. Lukas entered the room. Three chandeliers hung from the ceiling.*
+ viewpoint marker/past tense	*1b. Peter looked through the window. Outside the sun was shining.* *2b. Lukas observed the room. Three chandeliers hung from the ceiling.*
- viewpoint marker/present tense	*1c. Peter stands in front of the window. Outside the sun is shining.* *2c. Lukas enters the room. Three chandeliers hang from the ceiling.*
+ viewpoint marker/present tense	*1d. Peter looks through the window. Outside the sun is shining.* *2d. Lukas observes the room. Three chandeliers hang from the ceiling.*

Table 1 in the past tense without a viewpoint marker (1a), a quarter read the same story in the past tense with a viewpoint marker (1b), a quarter read this story in the present tense without a viewpoint marker (1c), and a quarter read this story in the present tense with a viewpoint marker (1d).

Instrumentation and procedure

The experiment was conducted online via Qualtrics, Provo, Utah. Participants were recruited via a participant pool including students and nonstudents. They were randomly assigned to one of the four versions of the experiment. At the start of the experiment participants read an introductory page with instructions. They were informed that they were about to read short stories that were narrated by an invisible narrator and that each story included a character. It was explained that the second sentence of each story was an observation that could be made by the narrator or by the character and that the participants would be asked to indicate to whom they would attribute the observation. An example story was presented on this introductory page.

Perceptual attributions were measured after each story with the following question: *Who, do you think, makes the observation in the second sentence?* Participants indicated their answer on a horizontal slide bar ranging from 0 (the narrator) to 100 (the character's name). The numbers on the bar were invisible to the participants such that they only saw the verbal labels marking the beginning and the end of the bar. To answer the question, participants were instructed to move a red dot by clicking on it with their mouse and dragging it to the left or the right. The dot was by default positioned at the exact middle of the slide bar (see Fig. 1 for an example). Each story was presented on a separate page in Arial 12.

Participation was anonymous and took on average 5 minutes. After completion, participants took part in a second (unrelated) study. At the end of this second study they were asked to indicate their gender, age, native language, nationality, and level of education.

Participants

A total of 128 participants took part in the study. Data from five participants were excluded because Dutch was not their native language. The final sample consisted of 123 native Dutch participants (82.9% women). Age ranged between 17 and 66, with a mean age of 27.5 (*SD* = 13.5). Level of education varied between participants: 11.4% received secondary education, 5.7% received middle-vocational training (Dutch MBO), 16.3% received a higher professional education (Dutch HBO), and 66.7% received a scientific education (Dutch WO). Of the participants, 60% took part in the study for course credit. The other 40% did not receive any compensation.

Results

To examine the effects of viewpoint markers and verb tense on readers' perceptual attributions, a linear mixed model analysis was conducted with subjects and items included as random factors and viewpoint markers and verb tense as fixed factors. Means and standard deviations for all four conditions are presented in Table 2.

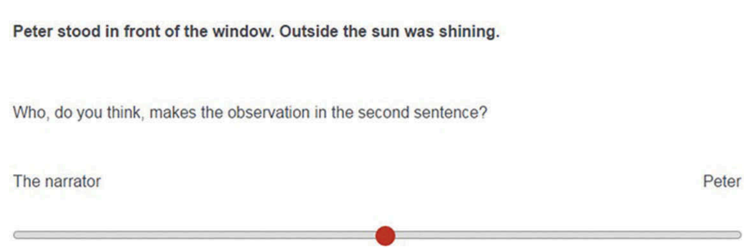

Figure 1. Example item from Experiment 1.

Table 2. Means and Standard Deviations (in Parentheses) for Perceptual Attributions as a Function of Viewpoint Markers and Verb Tense (0 = Narrator, 100 = Character).

With Viewpoint Marker		Without Viewpoint Marker	
Past Tense	Present Tense	Past Tense	Present Tense
65.39 (26.50)	65.77 (28.14)	38.30 (25.75)	37.55 (26.44)

Viewpoint markers had a highly significant effect on perceptual attributions (F (1, 8.307) = 58.00, $p < .001$). After reading a story with a viewpoint marker included in the first sentence, participants attributed the subsequent observation more strongly to the character (M = 65.58, SD = 23.63), whereas after reading a story without a viewpoint marker, participants attributed the subsequent observation more strongly to the narrator (M = 37.93, SD = 21.57). By contrast, no effect was found of verb tense on perceptual attributions (F (1, 8.307) < 1; M_{past} = 51.85, SD = 21.47, $M_{present}$ = 51.66, SD = 20.35). There was not an interaction effect between verb tense and viewpoint markers (F (1, 122) < 1). The results are shown in Figure 2.

Discussion

The results of Experiment 1 indicate that whereas verb tense does not affect perceptual attributions, linguistic viewpoint markers do: In stories without a viewpoint marker, readers tend to ascribe an ambiguous observation to the narrator, whereas in stories with such a marker, they tend to ascribe an ambiguous observation to the character. This result is in line with the contention that verbs of perception open up a character's mental space and that readers interpret the subsequent information as being filtered through this character's viewpoint (Sanders, 1994; Sanders & Redeker, 1996). By contrast, this result does not lend support to the assumption that in the absence of a linguistic viewpoint marker, readers automatically ascribe represented perceptions to the character rather than the narrator (Farner, 2014).

Although the results of this study provide initial insight into the effects of viewpoint markers and verb tense on readers' interpretation of ambiguous perspectives in narratives, they also give rise to further questions. First, the materials used in Experiment 1 consisted of stories of two sentences. A relevant question is to what extent viewpoint markers influence perceptual

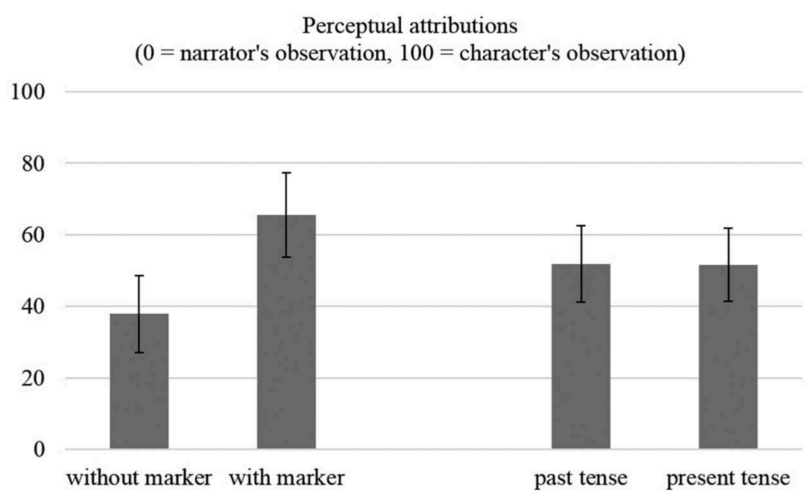

Figure 2. Mean perceptual attributions as a function of the absence versus presence of a viewpoint marker and the past tense versus present tense.

attributions in longer stretches of natural narrative discourse. A second, related question concerns the scope of perceptual attributions. It has been argued that characters' perspectives established by viewpoint markers "are by default continued unless it is signaled that they are interrupted" (Sanders, 1994, p. 189). Thus, readers are expected to continue ascribing ambiguous narrative observations to a character after this character's mental space is opened up by a linguistic viewpoint marker. An intriguing question is whether readers' perceptual attributions indeed remain stable as the narrative unfolds or whether they change in absence of subsequent viewpoint markers. In the second scenario, readers might even make a shift from ascribing observations to the character to ascribing observations to the narrator.

Third, the finding that verb tense does not appear to affect perceptual attributions and does not interact with linguistic viewpoint markers does not corroborate with the narratological and cognitive linguistic literature on the difference between the past tense and the present tense in terms of their function and presupposed effects (e.g., Damsteegt, 2005; Dancygier, 2012). This unexpected finding might be explained by the length of the materials used in Experiment 1. Stories of two sentences might be too short for the present tense to achieve its potential and establish the presumed link between the mind of the character and the mind of the reader (Damsteegt, 2005), especially because the narrated time lapse is of minimal duration. Contrary to the past tense, the present tense suggests that the time of narrating (by the narrator) and the time of reading (by the reader) coincide with the time of experiencing (by the character). This suggestion is likely strongest in stories in which a character actually experiences events that occur over a particular period of time (i.e., in stories in which time actually progresses). Thus, it might be possible that the conceptual difference between the present tense and the past tense only affects readers' interpretation of ambiguous perceptions when a story depicts a substantial period of time, including a series of events and observations rather than one isolated observation, as was the case in Experiment 1.

To examine the above possibilities, a second experimental study was conducted. The goals of Experiment 2 were to examine the influence of linguistic viewpoint markers and verb tense on perceptual attributions in longer stretches of natural narrative discourse and to examine the scope of these perceptual attributions. Details of this study are discussed below.

Experiment 2

Methods

Materials

The materials for Experiment 2 consisted of 12 short excerpts taken from fictional stories written by Dutch novelists Anna Blaman (*Feestavond [Party night]*, 1950; *Trocadero [Trocadero]*, 1940; *Engelen en demonen [Angels and demons*]; 1951), Kees Simhoffer (*De apotheek van Hippocrates [The pharmacy of Hippocrates]*, 1992), and J.M.A. Biesheuvel (*Een dag uit het leven van David Windvaantje [A day out of the life of David Windvaantje]*, 1978) and a Dutch translation of a story written by the American novelist Truman Capote (*Hilda [Hilda]*, 1941).

Each story began with one to four introductory sentences in which a character was introduced. In the subsequent part of the story a sequence of three observations was narrated. Each of the three observations was ambiguous in the sense that it could be made by the character or by the narrator. The stories were manipulated on the presence (vs. absence) of a linguistic viewpoint marker in the first part of the story and on verb tense (past vs. present). In some stories the original version included a viewpoint marker in the first part that was removed to create a version without a viewpoint marker. In other stories no viewpoint marker was present in the first part of the original version; for these stories a version was created in which a viewpoint marker was added. The manipulations resulted in four versions of each story. Table 3 provides two examples in each of the four story versions.

Table 3. Examples of the Story Versions Used in Experiment 2.

Story Version	Example 1
- viewpoint marker/past tense	*1a. Marianne walked through the hallway and opened the door. Despite the cool evening air, little droplets of sweat appeared on her forehead. She wiped them off with her forearm and stepped outside.*
+ viewpoint marker/past tense	*1b. Marianne walked through the hallway and opened the door. Despite the cool evening air, little droplets of sweat appeared on her forehead. She wiped them off with her forearm and looked outside, taken aback.*
- viewpoint marker/present tense	*1c. Marianne walks through the hallway and opens the door. Despite the cool evening air, little droplets of sweat appear on her forehead. She wipes them off with her forearm and steps outside.*
+ viewpoint marker/present tense	*1d. Marianne walks through the hallway and opens the door. Despite the cool evening air, little droplets of sweat appear on her forehead. She wipes them off with her forearm and looks outside, taken aback.*
Observations following each of the four story versions.	*(1) The man on the sidewalk was/is more than a head size smaller than her.* *(2) He wore/wears a tuxedo and held/holds his hat between both hands at his chest.* *(3) He had/has a round face and a lash of lusterless dark hair fell/falls over his forehead.*
Story Version	Example 2
- viewpoint marker/past tense	*2a. It was autumn and Miss Jannie was walking on an outer road. The garden was a little further. A lame fence separated it from the road. Jannie stood in front of that fence.*
+ viewpoint marker/past tense	*2b. It was autumn and Miss Jannie was walking on an outer road. The garden was a little further. A lame fence separated it from the road. Jannie stood in front of that fence and looked into the garden.*
- viewpoint marker/present tense	*2c. It is autumn and Miss Jannie is walking on an outer road. The garden is a little further. A lame fence separates it from the road. Jannie stands in front of that fence.*
+ viewpoint marker/present tense	*2d. It is autumn and Miss Jannie is walking on an outer road. The garden is a little further. A lame fence separates it from the road. Jannie stands in front of that fence and looks into the garden.*
Observations following each of the four story versions.	*(1) The earthen main path was/is overgrown by steep tufts of moss.* *(2) On either side was/is an unkempt lawn, dotted with mushrooms.* *(3) The bushes leaned/lean close together, craggily intertwined.*

In three instances the original story version included both a perceptual viewpoint marker and an emotional viewpoint marker. In the first example story in Table 3, for instance, the perceptual verb *looks* is combined with the phrase *taken aback*, which is also a viewpoint marker in the sense that it signals an emotion experienced by the character (van Krieken et al., 2017). These emotional viewpoint markers were not removed from the story version including a perceptual viewpoint marker to keep the authenticity of the stories and the external validity of the study as high as possible. In the story versions without a viewpoint marker, all linguistic markers of the character's observations and emotions were removed. Because the stories were short excerpts of longer stories, some minor adjustments had to be made to ensure that each excerpt formed a comprehensible and unified story part.

Design

As in Experiment 1, a 2 (viewpoint marker: present vs. absent) × 2 (verb tense: past vs. present) within-subjects design was used in which each participant read 12 stories: 3 stories in each of the four conditions. Again, a Latin square design was used with four versions of the experiment with the result that each story version was read by an equal number of participants.

Instrumentation and procedure

The procedure was similar to the procedure of Experiment 1. The experiment was conducted online via Qualtrics, and participants were recruited via a participant pool including students and non-students. After deciding to participate, participants were randomly assigned to one of the four versions of the experiment. At the start of the experiment, they read an introductory page with instructions. They were informed that they were about to read short stories that were narrated by an invisible narrator and that each story included a character. It was explained that the stories included a number of observations that each could be made by the narrator or by the character and that they would be asked to indicate to whom they would attribute these observations. An example story was presented on this introductory page.

Each story was presented on a separate page in Arial 12. After reading a story, participants clicked on a button to move on to the subsequent page on which the story was presented again. Below the story the final three sentences of the story were repeated. Each of these three sentences was followed by the question: *Who, do you think, makes this observation?* As in Experiment 1, participants indicated their answer by moving a red dot on a horizontal slide bar ranging from 0 (the narrator) to 100 (the character's name). The numbers on the bar were invisible to the participants such that they only saw the verbal labels.

Participation was anonymous and took on average 15 minutes. At the end of the study, participants were asked to indicate their gender, age, native language, nationality, and level of education.

Participants

A total of 91 Dutch participants took part in the study (79.1% women) for course credit or a gift voucher of €5. Age ranged between 18 and 44, with a mean age of 22.1 (SD = 4.61). Level of education varied between participants: 13.2% received secondary education, 5.5% received a higher professional education (Dutch HBO), and 81.3% received a scientific education (Dutch WO). All participants were native speakers of Dutch.

Results

The data were analyzed using linear mixed model analyses with subjects and items included as random factors and viewpoint markers and verb tense as fixed factors. The means and standard deviations are presented in Table 4.

For the perceptual attribution of the first observation following the introductory part of the stories, a significant effect of viewpoint markers was found (F (1, 8.198) = 19.32, p = .002). After reading an introduction with a viewpoint marker, the first observation was attributed more strongly to the character (M = 62.43, SD = 16.04) than after reading an introduction without a viewpoint marker (M = 47.94, SD = 15.35). The presence of a viewpoint marker had a marginal significant effect on readers' attribution of the second observation (F (1, 8.136) = 5.05, p = .054). After reading an introduction with a viewpoint marker, the second observation was attributed slightly more strongly to the character (M = 58.48, SD = 14.46) than after reading an introduction without a viewpoint marker (M = 48.13, SD = 14.61). Finally, a significant effect of viewpoint markers was found on the attribution of the third observation (F (1, 7.904 = 13.90, p = .006). After reading an introduction with a viewpoint marker, the third observation was attributed more strongly to the character (M = 56.00, SD = 16.74) than after reading an introduction without a viewpoint marker (M = 44.92, SD = 15.10).

Verb tense had no effect on the perceptual attribution of the first (F (1, 8.198) < 1), second (F (1, 8.136) < 1), or third (F (1, 7.904 = 2.97, p = .124) observation after the introductory part of the stories (first observation: M_{past} = 54.29, SD = 15.43, $M_{present}$ = 56.08, SD = 15.16; second observation: M_{past} = 52.60, SD = 13.53, $M_{present}$ = 54.01, SD = 14.28); third observation: M_{past} = 47.97, SD = 15.29, $M_{present}$ = 52.96, SD = 12.51). Figure 3 shows the results of the analyses. Finally, no interaction effects were found between viewpoints markers and verb tense on the perceptual attribution of the first (F (1, 8.198 < 1), second (F (1, 8.136 < 1), and third (F (1, 7.904) < 1) observation.

Table 4. Means and Standard Deviations (in Parentheses) for Perceptual Attributions as a Function of Viewpoint Markers and Verb Tense (0 = Narrator, 100 = Character).

	With Viewpoint Marker		Without Viewpoint Marker	
	Past Tense	Present Tense	Past Tense	Present Tense
First observation	62.19 (20.02)	62.67 (22.70)	46.39 (21.25)	49.49 (23.26)
Second observation	57.55 (20.02)	59.41 (21.00)	47.64 (19.34)	48.61 (22.13)
Third observation	53.14 (22.78)	58.87 (19.53)	42.80 (20.13)	47.04 (21.29)

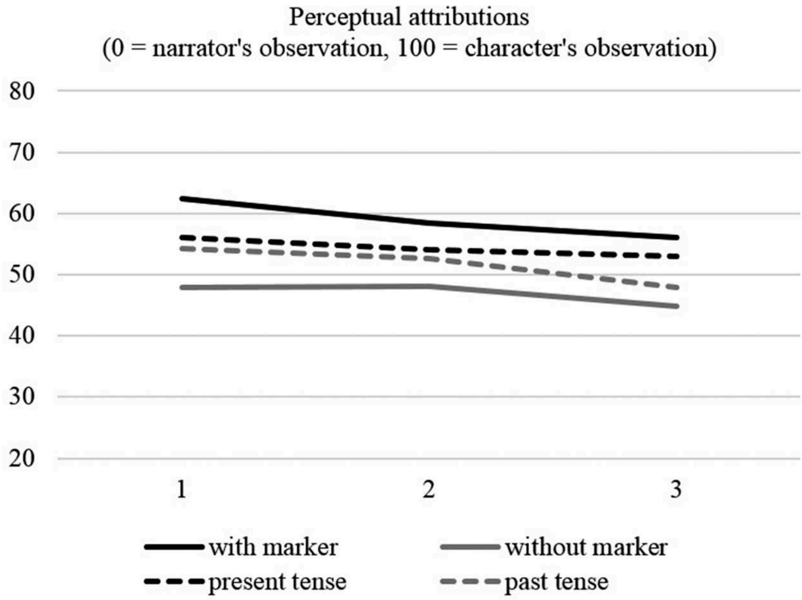

Figure 3. Mean perceptual attributions of three subsequent observations as a function of the presence versus absence of a viewpoint marker and the present versus past tense.

Discussion

Experiment 2 replicated and extended the results of Experiment 1. Viewpoint markers were shown to affect readers' perceptual attributions while processing short stories in which the perspective is ambiguous. Crucially, in this second study readers continued to ascribe observations more strongly to the character after this character's viewpoint had been linguistically encoded at the beginning of the story; the effect was found for three subsequent ambiguous observations. As in Experiment 1, verb tense had no effect on perceptual attributions. In addition, the absence of interaction effects indicates that the effect of linguistic viewpoint markers on perceptual attributions was not influenced by verb tense.

General discussion

The aim of this study was to empirically test theoretical claims about readers' interpretation of ambiguous perspectives in narratives. The results of both experiments provide support for the contention that linguistic viewpoint markers provide access to a narrative character's mental space and that, by consequence, readers interpret the following observations as observations of the character—even in the absence of subsequent viewpoint markers (Sanders, 1994; Sanders & Redeker, 1996). The support for this account is rather robust considering the correspondence between findings of the first study, in which 12 different stories of two sentences were used as stimulus materials, and findings of the second study, in which 12 longer, authentic stories were used. In broader terms, these results make a valuable contribution to research on stories by showing that Mental Spaces Theory (Fauconnier, 1985) provides a useful framework to examine the linguistic characteristics of narratives and formulate expectations about readers' processing of narratives (see also Sanders, 2010; van Krieken et al., 2016). Specifically, this framework takes into account both the multitude of viewpoints involved in stories and the highly dynamic and hence complex nature of shifts between these viewpoints (Dancygier, 2012). As such, it has the potential to advance research on the processing of narrative discourse by moving beyond the macro-level of first-person versus third-person stories and examining viewpoint phenomena at a micro-level instead.

The results of the two studies do not corroborate with the claim that readers automatically interpret represented perceptions as perceptions of the character (Farner, 2014) and, likewise, seem to contradict the assumption that when it can be inferred that a character has the *ability* to perceive the described events, readers interpret those events by default as actually being perceived by the character (Bortolussi & Dixon, 2003). In the stories without linguistic viewpoint markers in Experiment 1, readers tended to attribute ambiguous perceptions more strongly to the narrator. In Experiment 2 the mean scores in this condition were slightly below the neutral middle point of the scale, indicating that readers had no clear intuition about whether the observations were made by the narrator or the character. This result refines the findings by Sanford et al. (1998) by showing that referring to a character with a name (instead of a role description), as was the case in each of the stories in the present study, does not necessarily mean that readers attribute observations to this character; in the absence of a contextual viewpoint marker, they are more likely to attribute observations to the narrator (Experiment 1) or to refrain from clearly attributing observations to either the narrator or the character (Experiment 2).

Interestingly, the effect of viewpoint markers on perceptual attributions was unaffected by verb tense; the lack of an interaction between both factors indicates that present tense perceptual verbs and past tense perceptual verbs establish equally strong viewpoints. Moreover, verb tense in itself had no effect on perceptual attributions. In relation to the finding of previous studies that readers are more strongly inclined to adopt a character's perceptual perspective in present tense stories compared to past tense stories (Macrae, 2016; see also Segal et al., 1997), this suggests that verb tense does affect readers' processing of narrative discourse but not in terms of the perceptual attributions they make. Apparently, tense use can guide readers into aligning their viewpoints with the character's viewpoint, but this does not mean that they also ascribe ambiguous observations to this character. These findings combined stress the need for further research on tense use in narrative discourse in order to clarify which aspects of the reader's interpretative processes it does and does not influence.

Another opportunity for future research lies in an examination of other factors that might also play a role in the perceptual attributions readers make while reading stories. These may include factors related to the content of the story, for example, or personal traits such as reading behavior. People differ in their motives to read stories, ranging from a desire to gain deep insights and personal growth to a curiosity about the style of stories (Koopman, 2013, 2015). It is not unlikely that readers who deem the stylistics of stories important are more susceptible to subtle linguistic variations such as variations in viewpoint markers. In addition, future studies could assess the impact of alternative viewpoint markers on perceptual attributions. The Linguistic Cues Framework (van Krieken et al., 2017) offers a useful inventory of viewpoint markers for research in this direction.

An important conclusion to be drawn from this study is that perspectivization is indeed often ambiguous but that contextual viewpoint markers can fulfill a disambiguating role. Because viewpoint markers are a central characteristic of stories (van Krieken et al., 2015), this study has implications for our understanding of perspective at different levels. At the conceptual level this study demonstrates that perspective is a *discourse* phenomenon. Although linguistic viewpoint markers manifest at a very local level (i.e., the word level), their impact stretches to the discourse level: Once a character's viewpoint is established by a linguistic marker, readers continue to interpret the narrative information from this character's viewpoint. An intriguing question is under which conditions readers stay in and under which conditions they move out of the character's mental space (Sanders, 1994). Future studies could advance our understanding of how linguistic features guide readers' interpretation of stories by exploring which linguistic signals reinforce and which signals breach established perspectives.

At the functional level this study shows that readers' interpretation of stories is highly dependent on relatively subtle linguistic features such as perceptual verbs. This finding has consequences for authors and readers of various narrative genres. For example, linguistic viewpoint markers are ubiquitous not only in fictional narratives but also in nonfictional news narratives (van Krieken et al., 2016). Sanders and Redeker (1993) showed that these markers positively influence readers' appreciation of news narratives. The present study suggests that these markers can also affect their interpretation of the information provided. In a journalistic context, this may be problematic for the reason that the explicit attribution of information to sources is a core value in objective journalism (e.g., Berkowitz, 2009). A mutual understanding between journalist and reader of how stretches of narrative discourse with and without viewpoint markers are to be interpreted is crucial for journalistic stories to successfully fulfill their dual function of both informing and engaging the audience.

Finally, this study adds to the line of studies testing long-held assumptions about readers' interpretation of stylistic and linguistic variations in stories (e.g., Bray, 2007; Sotirova, 2006, 2016), responding to the call for studies addressing the role of viewpoint markers in readers' interpretation of narrative discourse (Foy & Gerrig, 2013). Although the approach taken in the current study appears fruitful in illuminating how the language of stories steers interpretative processes, several limitations require consideration. A first issue concerns the measurement of perceptual attributions, for which a continuous scale was used rather than a dichotomous choice between narrator and character. The scale allows for a refined measurement by taking into account the possibility that the telling (by the narrator) and the seeing (by the character) can fuse to a greater or lesser extent, such that an observation can be made by both the narrator and the character at the same time (cf. Stanzel, 1986). However, the question remains to what extent readers' interpretation of represented perceptions is equally refined and, therefore, to what extent their scorings reliably reflect the nature of their attributions. In addition, the means for the perceptual attributions readers made in the two studies mostly hovered relatively close to the middle of the scale. This raises the question as to how readers mentally represent a narrative passage in case they do not clearly attribute the information to either the narrator or the character and how such representations might differ from representations based on unambiguous representations. Future research could address this question, for example by including foil items that include perceptions that cannot reasonably originate in the character (e.g. *Peter looked at the ceiling of his bedroom. A hundred miles south, two dogs escaped from the shelter*.). Such studies could also use larger numbers of items to increase the generalizability of the results.

A second, related limitation of this study is that it measured explicit judgments, thus asking readers to consciously reflect on interpretation processes that, in a real-life setting, occur largely subconsciously. The instructions might have introduced unintended task demands by making an explicit distinction between the narrator and the character. A relevant question is to what extent the average reader is aware of this distinction, and, in particular when this awareness is low or absent, how readers interpret ambiguous perceptions if they are not explicitly asked to attribute such perceptions to the narrator or the character. Future studies could overcome this issue by using alternative measures, such as picture verification tasks or probe tasks in which readers have to assess whether a given object was part of the narrative world or not and whether that object has been perceived by the character or not (see, e.g., Horton & Rapp, 2003; Sanford et al., 1998; Yaxley & Zwaan, 2007).

Despite these limitations the present study contributes to our understanding of how readers interpret narrative discourse by showing that next to the macro-level difference between first- and third-person characters, micro-level viewpoint phenomena play a significant role in this process as well. As such, this study hopes to provide an impetus to future research on the role viewpoint markers play in this process. A combination of studies using explicit judgments and studies using implicit measures could mark a further step forward in our understanding of how linguistic variations influence readers' mental representation of narrative worlds and their characters.

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